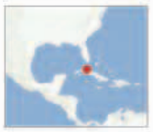
EIGHTY YEARS WAR

MATANZAS BAY



Date September 8, 1628
Forces Spanish: 4 galleons, 11 merchantmen; Dutch: 35 ships
Losses Spanish: all ships captured; Dutch: none

Location
Matanzas Bay, Cuba

Every year a treasure fleet sailed across the Atlantic carrying silver, gold, and valuable exotic goods to Spain from its American colonies, riches used to finance Spain's wars in Europe. In 1628 the Dutch West India Company sent warships to capture the treasure fleet, a feat never before achieved. They were led by Admiral Piet Heyn on board the 50-gun *Amsterdam*, with Witte de With as his flag captain. The Spanish treasure ships habitually sailed from Cartagena in Venezuela and Vera Cruz in Mexico, rendezvousing in Havana, Cuba, before crossing the Atlantic. Heyn waited off Havana for the ships to arrive. Warned of the Dutch presence the Cartagena squadron did not sail, but the Vera Cruz ships—four large galleons stuffed with bullion and 11 lesser merchantmen—approached Cuba on September 7.



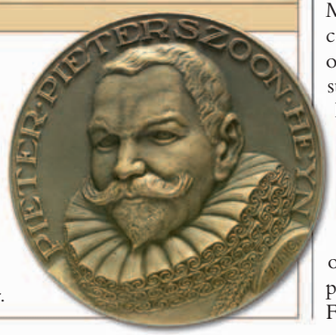
Spanish pieces of eight
The silver coins were minted in the Americas and shipped back to Europe—a tempting target for pirates and privateers.

The convoy was led by Juan de Benavides y Bazan, a man with influence at court but little personal merit. One of Heyn's ships ran into the fleet during the night and at dawn, firing a quick broadside, hastened away to report the contact. Although the Dutch ships were much smaller than the galleons, their collective firepower was formidable. Benavides did not rate his chances in a fight. Abandoning the merchantmen to capture, the galleons sought refuge in Matanzas Bay. But they were too heavily laden with cargo and passengers, and all four ran aground. The Dutch ships fired a few broadsides and then sent in boats that received the surrender of the galleons—from which senior officers had fled ashore—with hardly a shot fired. The captured treasure included 90 tons of silver and gold and was valued at 11.5 million guilders.

1577–1629

PIET HEYN

DUTCH NAVAL COMMANDER AND PRIVATEER



Born in Delftshaven, Heyn was a seafarer from boyhood. Twice captured by the Spanish, he served four years as a galley slave before joining the Dutch East India Company in 1607. He rose to captain and then, in the 1620s, vice admiral in the Dutch West India Company. He raided Spanish and Portuguese settlements and shipping in Africa, South America, and the West Indies, famously seizing the Spanish treasure fleet in 1628. Made Lieutenant Admiral of Holland in March 1629, he died fighting Dunkirk privateers three months later.

EIGHTY YEARS WAR

SLAAK



Date September 12–13, 1631
Forces Dutch: 50 boats; Spanish: 90 boats
Losses Dutch: unknown; Spanish: c.60 boats

Location Slaak channel, Scheldt estuary

The Spanish mounted an amphibious operation to seize strongpoints on the border between rebel Holland and Zeeland, embarking soldiers, under the Marquis of Aytona, on shallow-draft boats and sailing from Antwerp into the Scheldt. Forewarned of the incursion, the Dutch assembled 50 boats under Marinus Hollaer to intercept the convoy. Their attack on the evening of September 12 took the Spanish by surprise. The Dutch used their superior knowledge of the narrow channels and sandbanks to outmaneuver their enemy. Hundreds of Spanish drowned, jumping into the water in an attempt to escape. Aytona was among the few to return to Antwerp. The Admiralty of Amsterdam wanted the Spanish prisoners killed, but Dutch stadtholder Frederick Henry would not allow it.

PRIVATEER ACTION

DUNKIRK SORTIE



Date August 14–September 8, 1635
Forces Dunkirkers: 21 ships; Dutch: 35 warships
Losses Dunkirkers: unknown: Dutch c.120 fishing boats

Location
North Sea

Through most of the Dutch war of independence Dunkirk was controlled by the Spanish. They authorized the Dunkirkers to sail as privateers raiding Dutch merchant convoys and fishing fleets. The Dutch attempted to blockade Dunkirk to stop these attacks, but failed to prevent the privateers inflicting heavy losses. Jacob Collaart, vice admiral of the Dunkirk privateers, succeeded in running the blockade with 21 ships on August 14, 1635. Over the following five days he savaged two Dutch fishing fleets, driving off their armed escorts and sinking more than 120 herring boats. The Dutch sent every available warship in pursuit of the marauders. On August 21, a squadron of 20 Dutch ships under Lieutenant Admiral Filips van Dorp engaged the Dunkirkers near the Dogger Bank. They inflicted little damage and four of them were crippled by the Dunkirkers' guns. When 15 more Dutch warships arrived, Collaart skillfully disengaged. Taking advantage of poor weather, he slipped back into Dunkirk on September 8, carrying 975 Dutch fishermen as prisoners.



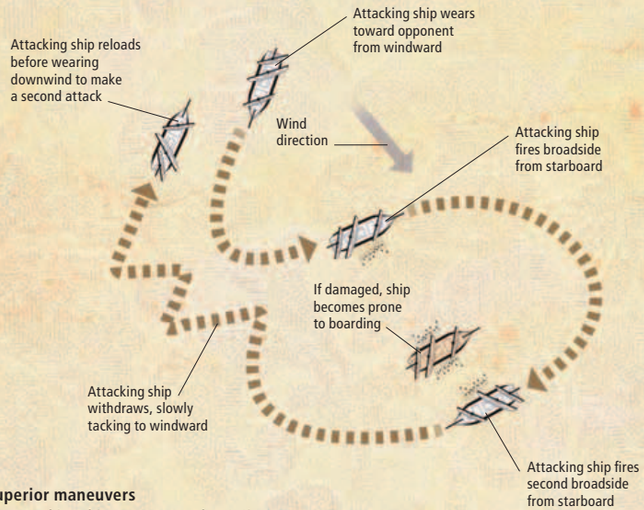
Dunkirk harbor
Throughout the 17th century Dunkirk was a hotbed of privateers, encouraged—first by the Spanish, then by the French—to attack Dutch and English convoys.

MAN-OF-WAR TACTICS

MÊLÉE TACTICS

MAKING MAXIMUM USE OF THE WIND

Before Europe's navies all started to adopt line-of-battle tactics in the mid-17th century, a naval battle in the open sea was a disorderly affair that could easily degenerate into a series of duels between individual ships. A skillful captain and crew would use their superior seamanship to outmaneuver an opponent, using the wind to wear and tack around the enemy, getting in as many shots as possible while avoiding the enemy's fire. The Dutch were particularly formidable opponents when this kind of mêlée developed.



Superior maneuvers
The attacking ship wears around a stationary enemy in order to unleash a second broadside and then tacks upwind to reload and get in a second attack. A duel between two ships could last a long time, sometimes a matter of hours if the crews were evenly matched.